

Khan: When I read a script, I am the audience. If it engages me, then I want to be a part of it. I was crying buckets when I heard *Taare Zameen Par*. Once that emotional journey was over for me, I said we have to make this film. I never sit back and think what should I do that can excite the audience or is this a script that can excite the audience?

Cameron: If I am writing, and I can't make myself cry or bring out an emotional reaction, then I don't believe in it. For me, it's not about pleasing a hypothetical audience based on what worked last year, or what the last successful film was. It's about pleasing the audience that I carry around at the back of my mind at all the times.

Khan: Till now, cinema was for a privileged few. Now with cellphones and digital cameras, everyone finally has a chance to make a film.

Cameron: You don't need to go through a hierarchy to become a director. Just get some friends together and make a film. Then you can go through the final cut on your laptop and can edit it. This kind of a democratic access to these tools of the trade is a way to compensate and people can come to you with an amazing short film for less money.

Khan: Storytelling will get more personalised in that manner. I know a number of people who are making short films. **Cameron:** There was a big hit film last year in the US, *Paranormal Activity* that cost \$20,000 to make. I don't even know how you feed the crew for a day. The production values were not very good, but they need not be because they



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(FROM LEFT) CAMERON, PURIE AND KHAN

kind of incorporated that amateur camera look into the style of the film, and so it worked.

Purie: Would 3D only work for a certain kind of films?

Cameron: I think a drama would strongly benefit if it is shot in 3D. We project our emotions into the people on the screen. And 3D heightens that experience. It gets more complicated compositing the images. And if you are doing a pure CG film, it's not a much additional cost. It's more expensive in the middle when it's a mixture of the two, which of course what *Avatar* was. But if you are doing a straight dramatic film, you can do it quite inexpensively in 3D.

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DISCUSSION

Q. How do you not get overwhelmed by the technology and focus on simple human emotions and thoughts?

Cameron: I think it is the discipline of doing big effect films by which one can stay emotionally present throughout the process.

Q. If you follow technology to the T, don't you have the fear of cinema becoming out and out sceptical?

Cameron: *Titanic* wouldn't have worked if it was merely sceptical or if I wasn't close to the feelings of the characters. It's a juxtaposition.

Q. When you make a film as a director, does it really change your perspective in life? If so, how?

Khan: It depends on what the material is. There have been times when I have read a script and it has changed the way I look at things.

Q. *Avatar* was a magical movie but why these ugly blue characters with tails?

Cameron: We started with the Na'vi characters looking more alien. Then they actually got more human as the design process got along because it's a love story and we had to be able to relate to them. But, I personally find them quite beautiful.

Q. Did you read Indian mythology? The blue characters of the film really looked like Lord Krishna.

Cameron: I have been in love with the imagery of India since I was a kid. I don't know why, I have just loved everything—the architecture, the mythology, the entire Hindu pantheon. When I was creating these aliens, all the warm tones were taken by the existing human race. Green was taken by the little green man. So we were left

with blue and purple.

Q. Do you see that a perceived anti-American sentiment of the film hurt it at the Oscars?

Cameron: It's a possibility I wouldn't discount. The film that won was pro-American military. Personally, I don't think my film is anti-American though it does try to say something about the incorrect use of military. I think that is very different then being anti-military because my main characters were military. In America, the way it works is you have to pick a movie, celebrate it and then you have to move on. I sort of feel that *The Hurt Locker* is that movie. I am not saying that to trivialise *The Hurt Locker*. I loved the film. When I read the script, I strongly recommended that Kathryn (Bigelow) make it as her next movie. The David-Goliath story is part of it—let's bring down the

successful film and celebrate the small independent one. That is something the Oscars have always done—bringing films to the attention of the world that it might not otherwise see, but must see.

Q. Would you again work for Vidhu Vinod Chopra or Raju Hirani after the success of *3 Idiots*? The next question is that you don't take awards. But would you allow your wife Kiran, if she wins a Filmfare for *Dhobi Ghat*, to go and take the award?

Khan: I have absolutely no control on what Kiran does. It's entirely her call. Vinod is someone who I am extremely fond of. The reason why I first came on to the project was because I was very keen on working with Raju. And I felt that he is such a wonderful director and I just wanted to work with him. He had a great script and I loved it.